

one that saw Google constantly evolve its technology. The company further added three Lexus RX450h crossovers to its fleet, cars which would soon become immediately identifiable with Google.

One big milestone was the licensing of the first autonomous vehicle in history, when one of Google's self-drive Toyota Prius cars was registered in Nevada, where it was testing its cars. The pattern chosen for identifying self-driving cars was a red background, with the infinity symbol to the left of the number plate, denoting 'one for the future'.

Simultaneously, it is Google's efforts in the autonomous vehicle space that first sparked off the now well known legal debates surrounding self driving cars. While it primarily originated in the US, the context was to adjust rules pertaining to Artificial Intelligence taking over. All driving rules, pretty much all over the world, have required the compulsory presence of a human in sound mental and physical condition behind a steering wheel. Now, with the need for steering wheel in question and drivers set to become mere passengers, the lawmakers called for discussions to revise laws pertaining to autonomous cars.

Regional implementation of laws surrounding autonomous cars were first facilitated by Google, beginning with the state of Nevada. Other states in the USA that now permit autonomous vehicle testing on public roads include Florida, California, Michigan and Texas. The laws have, for now, made the presence of a human imperative in any self-driven car. The person behind the wheel must also be in sound condition, and be able to intervene into the systems and take charge of the autonomous car whenever necessary. As a result, the person is also required to remain alert to his surroundings.

The on-road success has seen Google notch up over two million reported miles, making it the most experienced company so far when it comes to on-road autonomous driving. The company has since replaced its existing fleet of test cars with 23 Lexus SUVs, and more recently, struck a deal for 100 Chrysler Pacifica Hybrid minivans to test autonomous, ride-sharing journeys on road in Phoenix, Arizona.

Through all this, Google also built its own car, and killed it too. The Firefly was shown in its prototype form in May 2014, and it was unlike anything that we had seen before. It looked affable, was shaped like a pod, and only had two seats inside its cabin – no steering wheel, no pedals, nothing. It was launched by 2015, and was fitted with a beacon-like Velodyne 64 Lidar unit that provided a high definition, precise map of the